

Arthritis and Pet Ownership – UK Guide

Can you keep a pet with arthritis? UK guide to the benefits and challenges of pet ownership when living with arthritis, plus practical adaptations.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-01-05 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Pets can bring immense joy, companionship, and even health benefits to people with arthritis. But pet ownership also presents practical challenges when you have limited mobility or painful joints. Here's how to make it work.

Benefits of Pet Ownership with Arthritis

- Motivation to move — dog walking ensures regular low-impact exercise
 - Reduced loneliness — companionship reduces social isolation
 - Pain distraction — stroking a pet releases oxytocin and reduces pain perception
 - Routine — pets encourage a structured daily routine
 - Mental health — pet owners report lower rates of depression and anxiety
 - Studies show pet owners with chronic pain use fewer pain medications
-

Practical Challenges and Solutions



Openly licensed image via Openverse

Dog Walking

- Use a dog walking harness or lead with padded handle to reduce grip strain
- Choose routes with benches for rest stops
- Consider a dog walking service on flare days (from £10 per walk in most UK areas)
- Smaller dogs are easier to manage on lead
- Look into Cinnamon Trust — a UK charity that helps people with illness walk their dogs

Feeding

- Raised feeding bowls eliminate bending
- Use a scoop rather than lifting heavy bags
- Store food in a container at waist height
- Automatic feeders for cats can reduce daily effort

Grooming

- Choose breeds with low grooming needs if getting a new pet
- Use ergonomic grooming brushes with thick handles
- Consider professional grooming every 6-8 weeks

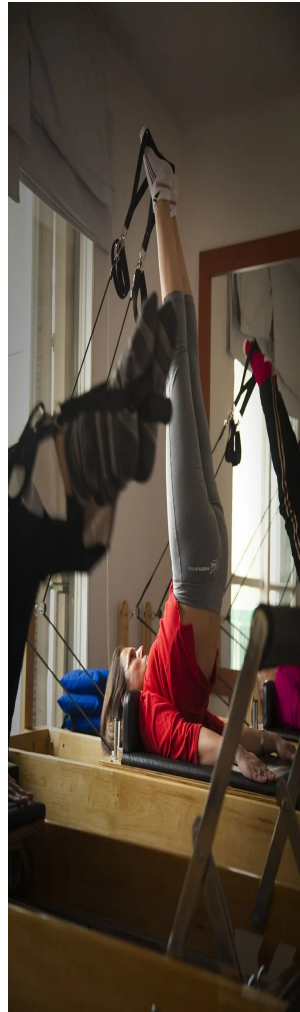
Litter Trays (Cats)

- Self-cleaning litter trays reduce manual scooping
 - Place the tray at a comfortable height
 - Use lightweight clumping litter that's easier to handle
-

Choosing the Right Pet

- Low-energy dog breeds — Cavalier King Charles Spaniel, Shih Tzu, Greyhound (surprisingly lazy!)
 - Cats — independent, require less physical management
 - Small pets — rabbits, guinea pigs — lower physical demands
 - Consider an older rescue pet — less energetic, already trained
-

UK Support Services



Openly licensed image via Openverse

- Cinnamon Trust — volunteers help walk dogs and foster pets if you're hospitalised
- PDSA — free vet care for eligible pet owners
- Blue Cross — financial assistance for pet healthcare
- Dogs for Good — assistance dogs for people with physical disabilities

A pet can be a wonderful companion on your arthritis journey. With the right planning and support, pet ownership is absolutely possible.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about arthritis and pet ownership – uk guide?

Short answer: Pet ownership can benefit people with arthritis by providing motivation to move, reducing loneliness, distracting from pain, and encouraging routine. Challenges like dog walking, feeding, and grooming can be managed by using adapted equipment, choosing appropriate pets, and utilising services like dog walkers or professional groomers. Organisations such as Cinnamon Trust offer support.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk